

# "Social Media or Websites?": A Quantitative Investigation on Preferences of Buyers and Sellers in Bangladesh

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## Abstract

Social media and websites have emerged as the dominant platforms for online shopping, each catering to distinct user preferences. To the best of our knowledge, this study is the first to examine both buyer and seller preferences between these platforms and the underlying reasons for their choices in the context of Bangladesh. We have surveyed 105 participants through live interviews and Google forms, including 20 sellers who are also buyers. We have used Cramér's V test, network analysis, and frequency analysis to analyze the associations of different factors. Our findings suggest that while websites remain the preferred shopping platform, the ease of use and intuitive interface of social media play a critical role in maintaining its relevance. Additionally, social media is an effective tool for building trust, shaping customer behavior, and establishing market presence. These insights offer online sellers valuable guidance on tailoring their strategies to maximize platform effectiveness.

## CCS Concepts

• Human-centred Computing → Collaborative and Social Computing.

## Keywords

Online Shopping, Social Media, Website, E-commerce, Quantitative Analysis

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## 1 Introduction

The exponential growth of e-commerce worldwide has transformed customer shopping behavior, with social media and websites now dominating online transactions. Bangladesh, as a developing country, has embraced this digital shift, driven by improved Internet access and a growing online market. This expansion began in the early 2000s [28]. Government policies and enhanced IT infrastructure, including the introduction of 2G and 3G networks, have further fueled this growth. Bangladesh Bank permitted online transactions in 2009 and accepted foreign credit cards in 2013. By 2014, online shopping exceeded Tk. 3.5 billion, with Facebook-based commerce driving over 60% of sales during Eid [10].

The COVID-19 pandemic significantly accelerated this shift, as lockdowns forced customers to turn to online channels for essential purchases. In 2020, online shopping in Bangladesh surged by 70% compared to the previous year [8]. According to eCommerceDB [7], Bangladesh is now the 36th largest e-commerce market globally, with revenues projected to reach USD 7,895.7 million by 2024. The sector is expected to grow by 37.1% in 2024 and contribute notably to global expansion. With a projected 22.3% CAGR, the market is forecasted to reach USD 17,647.3 million by 2028. While online shopping is gaining popularity in Bangladesh, numerous studies have explored its challenges and customer perceptions. However, there is a lack of comparative studies on how social media and websites, both together and individually, address the diverse needs of Bangladeshi customers, which is crucial for optimizing e-commerce strategies.

Considering buyer and seller preferences, platform capabilities, and their comparative analysis with traditional shopping experiences, we have aimed to address the research gap by focusing on the following research questions:

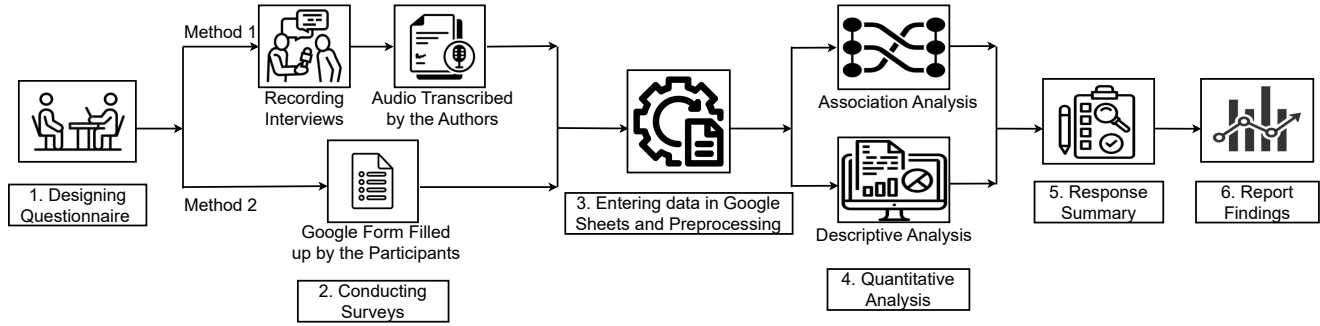


Figure 1: Data Collection and Analysis Workflow on Social Media and Website Preferences

- **RQ1:** How do different factors influence the preferences of users (buyers and sellers) in social media and websites in Bangladesh?
- **RQ2:** Can social media or websites individually satisfy the diverse demands of online shopping in Bangladesh?
- **RQ3:** To what extent do social media platforms replicate or enhance the traditional shopping experience compared to websites, from the perspectives of buyers?

Our research has begun with designing a structured questionnaire and collecting data through live interviews and Google forms. We have used frequency analysis to examine buyer and seller preferences, along with Cramér's V test and network analysis to explore associations between various factors. The results show that, despite the widespread use of social media, people still prefer websites. However, social media advertisements, reviews, and feedback are crucial in maintaining its relevance. These insights will help businesses develop strategies that effectively integrate social media and websites, enhancing user experiences and fostering sector growth.

## 2 Literature Review

Numerous studies have been conducted to examine various aspects of online shopping through social media and websites. The background study is conducted to facilitate the creation of the theory for our work.

### 2.1 Consumer Preferences in Bangladesh: Online Shopping versus Traditional Shopping

Studies on Bangladeshi consumers' shopping preferences show mixed results. Suhan [28] finds that while most participants see online shopping easier, some prefer in-store shopping. This high preference for online shopping is partly due to the return policies of e-commerce sites. Customers can return products if they feel dissatisfied or if their preferences change. Rahman et al., [24] highlight that a key drawback of online shopping is the inability to physically inspect products. So, online shoppers prefer cash on delivery, though multiple payment options are available.

### 2.2 User Experience and Attitude towards Online Shopping

Foxall et al., [11] identify three shopping perspectives: the importance of the shopping experience, attitudes toward comparative

shopping, and views on branded products. Consequently, marketing expert Phillip Kotler [31] outlines three stages of online buying: pre-purchase (information search and evaluation), purchase (ordering and payment), and post-purchase (delivery and customer relationships). A study by Zhou [33] hypothesizes that website design significantly impacts customer attitudes, with better designs encouraging positive attitudes and impulsive purchases. Well-designed websites with appealing features and easy-to-use search tools also lead to positive reviews [2]. In addition to websites, marketing on Facebook and Twitter makes young Bangladeshi consumers more inclined to buy. Still, organizations must remember that client behaviors evolve, especially online. So, they must occasionally observe customer behavior and upgrade their products and services to their demands [24]. Recent research highlights that convenience, price, trust, and user experience significantly shape online shopping behavior, though consumer perceptions of risks and comfort vary widely [16].

### 2.3 Consumer Trust in Online Shopping

A study from Alzaidi et al., [3], has indicated that the intention to purchase is contingent upon privacy concerns and trust. Information quality, security concerns, ease of use, the privacy/security assurance seal, and a willingness to accept third-party certification are the main drivers of trust and privacy concerns. Even if consumers are unfamiliar with a website, familiarity with online transactions and initial trust positively impact their purchase intentions [5]. Again, a study by Malik et al., [19] finds that security concerns, vendor trust, product quality, and an appealing web interface may influence online shopping intentions, but they may not lead to actual purchases. Simplicity of use, prior experiences, and compatibility are more beneficial in affecting behavior. It is also noted that customers are less likely to buy services if they believe they have a physical shop, unlike for less essential items. Hacking, theft, spam, and online scams are common topics in the news, which makes people more suspicious and wary of online transactions. The customers' worry and risk views are also raised because they are physically far away, lack human interaction [13]. Recent studies further emphasize the role of trust in online shopping. For instance, research on consumer trust and online purchase intention for sustainable products highlights that perceived risk, security, and privacy significantly predict trust in e-commerce, which in turn influences online purchase intentions for sustainable products [26]. Cross-market studies reveal that company reputation, security, and website quality boost trust, directly impacting purchase intentions,

while customer reviews and their authenticity significantly shape consumer trust and behavior [20, 23].

## 2.4 Gaps in Current Research

Several studies have addressed the necessity of social media marketing for online shopping. Several studies have compared how likely people are to buy something online based on recommendations from friends on social media and reviews on shopping websites that people cannot see [9, 21]. However, the comprehensive comparison of websites and social media concerning online shopping from the viewpoints of both buyer and seller has not been previously examined in Bangladesh. Currently, Internet shopping is essential, necessitating a comparative analysis of its acceptance across websites versus social media platforms.

## 3 Methodology

We have begun our study by designing a comprehensive questionnaire, followed by data collection through live interviews and Google forms filled out by the participants. Once gathered, the data have been processed and analyzed to derive meaningful insights. Figure 1 provides a detailed overview of the research methodology employed in this study.

### 3.1 Interview Process Design

The questionnaire has been developed to compare social media and websites from the perspectives of both buyers and sellers. It has been structured around four key aspects: the effectiveness of advertising on social media, the impact of online feedback and reviews on buyers, the preferred medium for online shopping, and the feasibility of using these mediums for business growth and operations. To better understand business growth from the perspective of sellers, we have included specific questions targeted at sellers.

### 3.2 Data Collection

Data has been collected through live interviews and Google forms. To maintain diversity among the data, participants are selected from various regions across Bangladesh. Participation is voluntary and requires prior consent from the participants. The live interviews have been recorded, transcribed, and analyzed. On the other hand, the Google forms data have been transferred into Google Sheets and analyzed.

### 3.3 Data Entry And Preprocessing

Responses to each question have been categorized to ensure ease of analysis. The responses have been carefully reviewed and included in the final analysis to ensure its integrity. The responses have been then mapped into distinct categories based on identified keywords and key themes. This categorization process has allowed for a more organized analysis, ensuring that each response is aligned with the specific focus of the study.

### 3.4 Data Analysis

We have started by analyzing the frequency of each unique entry for each question within the responses which offered insight into prevalent patterns and trends within the data. To explore the association between variables, Cramér's V test along with network analysis has been used. Cramér's V measures the strength of association between two categorical variables. The value of Cramér's

V ranges from 0 to 1, where values closer to 1 indicate a stronger association between variables. Findings have been reported based on frequency analysis, network analysis, and association analysis.

## 3.5 Ethical Considerations and Approval

To ensure ethical compliance in our research involving human participants, we have obtained official approval from the Bangladesh University of Engineering and Technology (BUET). This approval, granted on 30th October 2024, follows a comprehensive review by the regulatory committee of the university of the design of our study, data collection methods, and participant protection measures. This authorization verifies that our study adheres to established ethical standards, prioritizing the confidentiality, rights, and well-being of participants. This approval reflects our commitment to conducting research responsibly and ethically, safeguarding the integrity of the study and the trust of its participants.

## 4 Findings

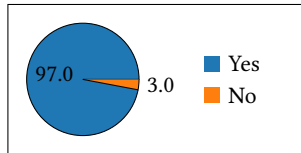
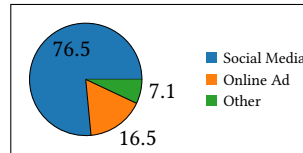
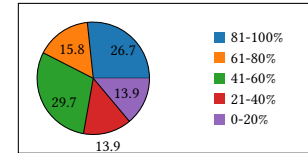
Our study have been conducted on 105 participants, including 20 sellers who are also buyers. The sample size aligns with established practices, where the choice depends on the goals and context of each study. According to a relevant research study [4], which conducts a systematic literature review of 560 studies published at CHI, sample sizes range from 1 to 916,000, with the most common being 12 participants. Here, 57 studies reported a sample size of 12, and 20% of studies reported a sample size of 10 or fewer. While half of all studies had a sample size of less than 18, 70% of all the studies reported a sample size of fewer than 30 participants. These findings highlight that there is no universally adopted sample size, and the choice should be driven by the design, analytical requirements, and practical constraints of the study. Accordingly, the number of participants in our research ensures a robust and reliable data set that will allow us to identify meaningful patterns and statistical relationships. Having a larger sample than the median used in many studies enhances our ability to generalize the findings across our target population. Therefore, this approach not only aligns with established HCI standards but also strengthens the validity and reliability of our results, ensuring that our analysis provides accurate insights into the preferences of both buyers and sellers. The demographic information of the participants is presented in Table 1. The findings of the four key aspects of our study are stated in the following subsections.

### 4.1 Social Media as a Superior Advertising Platform

A summary of the responses regarding social media as a superior advertising platform is illustrated in Figure 2. The study reveals that 71.3% of participants check their emails regularly, at least once a day. However, 59.4% of these participants can be contacted through social media. Notably, 90.1% agree that social media serves as an effective advertising platform. Furthermore, a majority (97%) believe that promotions or special offers can be effectively broadcast via social media. Regarding social media use in rural areas, 42.57% of participants think that over 60% of the rural population uses social media at a moderate rate, defined as checking social media 2-3 times daily.

**Table 1: Demography of the participants**

| Variables                            | Particulars             | Frequency | Percent(%) |
|--------------------------------------|-------------------------|-----------|------------|
| Gender                               | Female                  | 56        | 53.3       |
|                                      | Male                    | 49        | 46.7       |
| Education                            | Undergraduate or higher | 85        | 80.9       |
|                                      | Below Undergraduate     | 20        | 19.1       |
| Smartphone User                      | Yes                     | 103       | 98.1       |
|                                      | No                      | 2         | 1.9        |
| Hours spent on Social Media          | 0-1                     | 7         | 6.67       |
|                                      | 1-2                     | 16        | 15.23      |
|                                      | 2-3                     | 28        | 26.67      |
|                                      | 3-4                     | 28        | 26.67      |
|                                      | More than 4             | 26        | 24.76      |
| Frequency of Online Product Purchase | >1 times/week           | 9         | 8.6        |
|                                      | 1-2 times/month         | 39        | 37.1       |
|                                      | 3-4 times/year          | 26        | 24.7       |
|                                      | 1-2 times/year          | 25        | 23.8       |
|                                      | Very rare               | 6         | 5.8        |

**(a) Social media boosts promotion****(b) Mass media advertising****(c) % of rural social media users****Figure 2: Summary of social media as a superior advertising platform.**

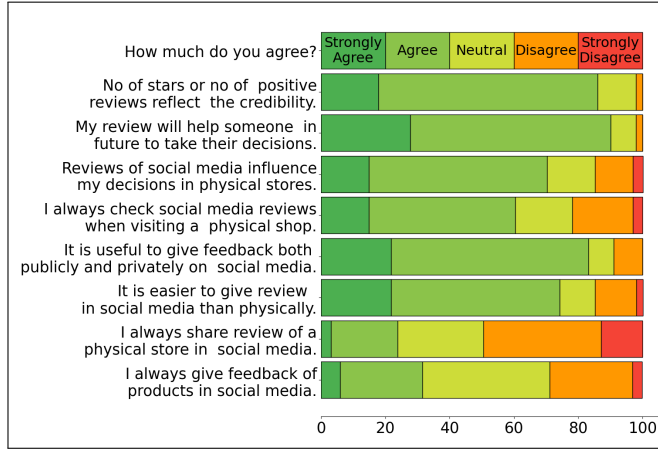
## 4.2 The Influence of Feedback and Reviews

Figure 3a summarizes the responses related to the influence of feedback and reviews. The findings reveal mixed behavior in terms of sharing reviews on social media. While 31.7% of participants actively share their feedback, 28.7% choose not to, and another 39.6% only provide reviews when their experience is exceptionally positive or negative. Notably, only 23.8% have left reviews for physical stores online. Despite this low rate of sharing, a significant 90.1% believe that their reviews could be beneficial to others in the future. The weak association of 0.086 between consistently sharing reviews of physical stores on social media and the belief that reviews are helpful suggests these two aspects are independent; believing in the potential usefulness of reviews does not necessarily compel individuals to share them. Interestingly, 74.1% of participants find it easier to share feedback on social media platforms, with 83.2% appreciating the option to post either anonymously or publicly. Social media reviews have a notable impact on consumer behavior, as 60.4% check social media review actively and 70.3% of participants admit that their decisions to visit physical stores and selection of products are influenced by these reviews. Furthermore, 86.1% perceive the number of positive reviews or star ratings as a measure of credibility. A strong association of 0.6 between the influence of social media in selecting physical stores and checking social media reviews before visiting indicates that reviews play a significant role in the selection of shops. The strong association (0.41) between ease of leaving reviews on social media and frequent feedback sharing contrasts with the weak association (0.18) between the perceived

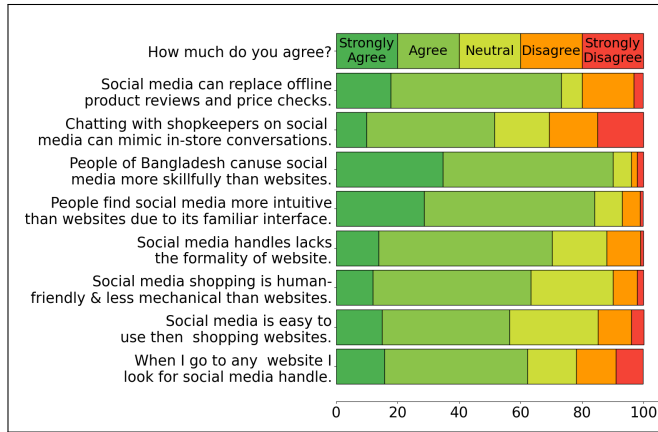
usefulness of review types and the habit of always sharing, highlighting that ease of use plays a greater role in feedback sharing than anonymous review features.

## 4.3 Buyer Shopping Preferences

Figure 3b, Figure 5a and 5b provide a summary of the responses related to the shopping preferences of the buyers. The study indicates that 47.5% of participants prefer shopping via websites, while 39.6% favor social media, and 10.9% use both platforms. Despite a majority showing a preference for websites, 62.4% still seek out social media handles when visiting a website, emphasizing the significance of maintaining a social media presence for business. Interestingly, while websites hold a slight preference, 56.4% of participants find social media easier to use. Additionally, 63.2% view social media as more human-friendly and less mechanical than websites, with 70.3% appreciating its informal nature. Overall, 84.2% of participants believe that social media is more intuitive for the general population in Bangladesh due to its familiar interface compared to the varying designs of websites. Moreover, 90.1% think that people are more skillful at navigating social media for shopping than traditional websites. When comparing online shopping with in-store experiences, 37.6% perceive social media as being closer to the physical shopping experience, while 28.7% believe websites provide a similar experience, and 13.9% consider both to be alike. Notably, 51.5% state that chatting with sellers on social media replicates in-store interactions, and 73.3% believe that exploring various shops on social media mirrors the process of product research and price



(a) Influence of review and feedback on buyer



(b) Shopping preferences of the buyers

**Figure 3: Likert scale questions and frequency of responses of shopping preferences and feedback influence**

estimation in physical markets. Interestingly, there is a moderate association of 0.23 between replicating physical store experiences and the preference for social media as the primary shopping platform, indicating a lack of association between these aspects. Conversely, the relatively strong association of 0.33 between the ease of using social media and its preference for online shopping suggests that the primary reason for selecting social media as a shopping platform is its operational simplicity.

#### 4.4 Feasibility of Social Media and Websites for Business Growth and Operations

Figure 4 summarizes the responses on business growth using shopping platforms. The study reveals a notable preference for social media among sellers, with 96.5% of respondents indicating their intention to establish a social media presence for their business. Additionally, 90.6% prefer social media over websites as their primary business platform. Trustworthiness is strongly associated with social media activity; 78.2% of participants perceive shops with frequent social media engagement as more reliable, and 86.1% believe that recognizable shop names enhance credibility. There is a significant association of 0.59 between these two aspects, further

highlighting that increased social media activity can bolster trustworthiness. Furthermore, 70.3% of buyers are positively influenced by repeated exposure to a shop's name on social media. 48.5% of the participants respond positively to seeing the shop again on social media after purchase, while 20.8% have a negative reaction and 16.8% exhibit mixed feelings. The moderately strong association of 0.32 between the influence of social media on shop selection and repeated exposure after a purchase indicates that customers influenced by social media are less likely to be annoyed by post-purchase visibility and are more inclined to buy again. Social media reviews significantly shape customer perceptions. Approximately 60.3% of participants consult social media reviews when visiting physical shops, and 55.4% report being highly influenced by these reviews. Additionally, the moderately strong association of 0.32 suggests that buyers who check social media reviews before visiting a physical shop are also inclined to create social media handles for their own businesses.

#### 4.5 Seller Insights on the Impact of Social Media vs. Websites

Figure 5c summarizes the perspective of the seller. Notably, 75% of sellers indicate that social media platforms are easier to manage and maintain compared to websites. Furthermore, 68.8% of sellers concur that social media offers better visibility for their products than traditional websites. All sellers (100%) unanimously agree that they receive a higher volume of customer inquiries through social media, fostering personal connections and trust with customers. Additionally, 68.7% of sellers believe that social media plays a crucial role in enhancing the reputation, while only a small 6.25% express disagreement. Moreover, 100% of sellers agree that social media offers superior tools for advertising and promotion. No sellers dispute that social media is updated more frequently and generates higher sales compared to websites. All sellers (100%) affirm that having a social media presence is more important than maintaining a website.

### 5 Discussion

By analyzing the observations of both buyers and sellers, we acquire significant insights into their online purchasing and selling activities. This section addresses the research questions of this study and then compare our findings with related studies to underscore our contributions.

#### 5.1 Impact of Diverse Factors over Buyer and Seller Preferences (RQ1)

The findings demonstrate a clear alignment with RQ1, highlighting that factors such as ease of use, human friendliness, minimal formalities, and an intuitive interface significantly influence buyer preferences for social media over websites. Specifically, 56.4% of participants find social media easier to navigate, while 63.2% perceive it as more human-friendly. Statistical analysis using Cramér's V reveals a strong relationship between shopping preferences and these factors, with correlations of  $P = 0.33$  for ease of use and  $P = 0.55$  for human friendliness. Prior research by Datta et al., [6], Islam et al., [15], and Ahmed et al., [1], has also identified similar factors that influence buyer preferences for social media shopping, including convenience and ease of service. Furthermore, the ability of social media to replicate physical store experiences such as reviews, price

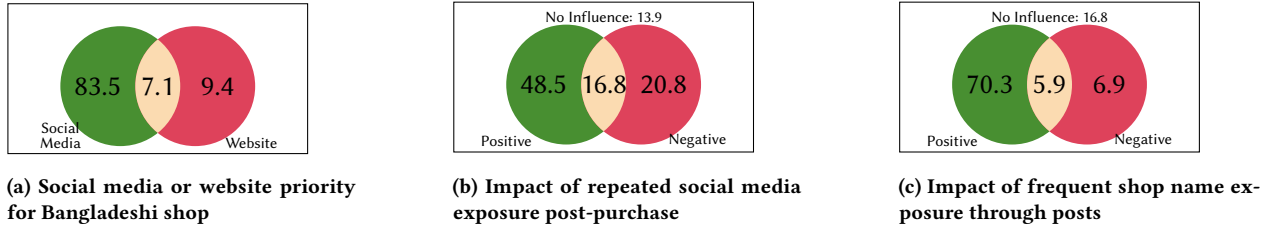


Figure 4: Perspective of people on growing business in social media.

Table 2: Analysis over the Impact of Social Media and Websites

| Research Study             | Method               | Location      | No. of Participants             | Analysis over the impact of |          | Analysis over the preferences of |        |
|----------------------------|----------------------|---------------|---------------------------------|-----------------------------|----------|----------------------------------|--------|
|                            |                      |               |                                 | Social Media                | Websites | Buyer                            | Seller |
| Rahman [25]                | Survey               | Bangladesh    | 83                              | ✓                           | x        | ✓                                | x      |
| Datta et al., [6]          | Survey               | Bangladesh    | 166                             | x                           | ✓        | ✓                                | x      |
| Islam et al., [14]         | Interview            | Bangladesh    | 35                              | ✓                           | x        | ✓                                | x      |
| Sultana et al., [29]       | Survey               | Bangladesh    | 140                             | ✓                           | x        | ✓                                | x      |
| Mahmud et al., [18]        | Survey               | Bangladesh    | 301                             | x                           | ✓        | ✓                                | x      |
| Islam et al., [15]         | Survey               | Bangladesh    | 291                             | ✓                           | x        | ✓                                | x      |
| Ahmed et al., [1]          | Survey               | Bangladesh    | 150                             | ✓                           | ✓        | ✓                                | x      |
| Nahida Sultana [30]        | Survey               | Bangladesh    | 110                             | ✓                           | x        | ✓                                | x      |
| Saha et al., [27]          | Survey               | Bangladesh    | 210                             | x                           | ✓        | ✓                                | x      |
| Alzaidi et al., [3]        | Survey               | Saudi Arabia  | 1200                            | ✓                           | x        | ✓                                | x      |
| Venkatesh et al., [32]     | Survey               | North America | 9992                            | x                           | ✓        | ✓                                | x      |
| Papagiannidis et al., [22] | Survey               | UK            | 603                             | ✓                           | x        | ✓                                | x      |
| Erkan et al., [9]          | Interview            | UK            | 384                             | ✓                           | ✓        | ✓                                | x      |
| Latief et al., [17]        | Survey               | Indonesia     | 96                              | ✓                           | x        | ✓                                | x      |
| Hoque et al., [12]         | Survey               | Bangladesh    | 200                             | x                           | ✓        | ✓                                | x      |
| Our Study                  | Interview and Survey | Bangladesh    | 105 (Interview: 68, Survey: 37) | ✓                           | ✓        | ✓(105)                           | ✓(20)  |

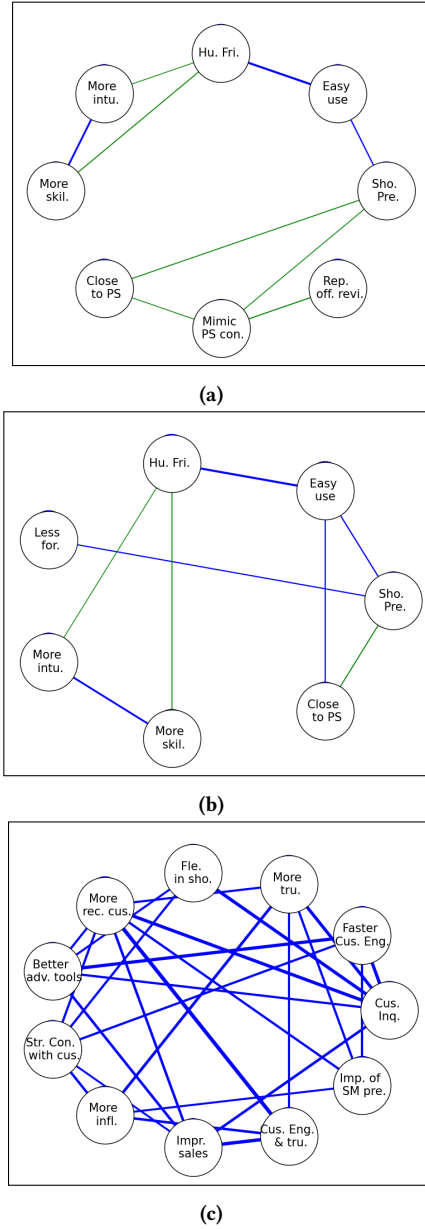
comparisons, and conversations akin to offline shopping, further influences consumer preferences.

All sellers unanimously prefer social media over websites for its ease of management, greater product visibility, higher customer inquiry volume, reputation enhancement, superior advertising tools, and the importance of social media presence compared to maintaining a website. In Addition, advertising also plays a crucial role, with 90.1% of respondents acknowledging social media as an effective advertising platform, particularly in rural areas. This assertion is supported by studies from Sultana et al., [29], Erkan et al., [9], and Islam et al., [14], which identify customer reviews as key factors impacting shopping preferences. The findings reflect that the human-centric approach of social media renders the platform more attractive compared to website-based purchasing.

## 5.2 Evaluating the Ability to Fulfill the Diverse Demands of Buyers (RQ2)

The findings suggest that neither social media nor websites alone can fully meet the diverse demands of online shopping. Social media is favored for advertising, customer engagement, and replicating the physical shopping experience, while websites are trusted for secure transactions. While 39.6% of buyers prefer social media, 47.5% still favor websites for shopping. The remaining participants exhibit a mixed preference, reflecting the dual nature of customer needs. This overlap is further emphasized by the fact that 62.4% of participants seek out social media handles when visiting a website, highlighting the importance of a hybrid approach. Ahmed et al., [1], also found that social media is the primary source of information for online shopping, followed closely by websites.

Studies by Sultana et al., [29] and Alzaidi et al., [3] indicate that websites are perceived as more suitable for transactions due to their credibility and established trust. These studies underscore the significance of trust and privacy concerns, which greatly influence



**Figure 5: A network graph based on Cramér’s V test illustrates: (a) the association between user preferences for social media (b) online shopping websites. Blue edges represent strong associations ( $P \geq 0.3$ ), while green edges indicate moderate associations ( $0.2 \leq P < 0.3$ ) (Shopping preferences: Sho. Pre., Physical Shopping: PS, Human-Friendly: Hu. Fri., Needs less formality: Less for., More intuitive: More intu., More skillful: More skil., Replace offline reviews and price checks: Rep. off. revi., SM chat Mimic PS Conversation: Mimic PS con.) (c) sales preferences are more strongly associated ( $P \geq 0.3$ ) with social media than website (Customer inquiries: Cus. Inq., Faster Customer engagement: Faster Cus. Eng., More trustable: More tru., Flexibility in showcasing products: Fle. In sho., More recurring customers: More rec. cus., Better advertising tools: Better adv. Tools, Stronger personal connection: Str. Con. with cus., Customer feedback more influential: More infl., Improve sales: Impr. Sales, Customer engagement and trust: Cus. Eng. & tru., Importance of SM presence: Imp. of SM pre.)**

purchasing intentions. Our findings are consistent with this, as evidenced by Cramér’s V test ( $P=0.27$ ), indicating that social media is perceived as less trustworthy for transactions. However, we also offer a contrasting perspective: social media is considered more trustworthy for selling and buying when stronger personal connections are fostered through chatting and customer engagement on social media, as illustrated in Figure 4. These findings strongly support the notion that both platforms play complementary roles, which aligns with RQ2, demonstrating that both are essential to address the multifaceted demands of Bangladeshi consumers.

### 5.3 Assessing the Experiences of Shopping (RQ3)

RQ3 is key to understanding how effectively social media replicates the traditional shopping experience compared to websites. The findings reveal that 37.6% of participants believe social media offers a shopping experience closer to physical stores than websites. This is further supported by social media features like chatting with sellers, which 51.5% of respondents feel effectively mimicking in-store interactions. While traditional shopping retains its appeal for unique experiential aspects such as bargaining and browsing [6], social media has managed to replicate these elements more engagingly.

Additionally, factors such as personal psychology, culture, and technology are significant drivers of online shopping behavior [32]. A notable 73.3% of participants enjoy browsing multiple shops on social media, likening it to the research and price comparison they would typically undertake in physical markets. These findings underscore the ability of social media to recreate key aspects of traditional shopping, especially in facilitating interpersonal interactions between buyers and sellers.

Beyond accessibility, social media is favored for its capacity to foster trust through visibility and interaction. Approximately 78.2% of participants believe shops active on social media are more trustworthy, while 86.1% think that a strong social media presence enhances the credibility of a shop. This suggests that social media not only simulates the traditional shopping experience but also strengthens it by offering real-time engagement and trust-building opportunities, something that websites often struggle to replicate.

### 5.4 Comparative Analysis

Table 2 presents a summary of key aspects from similar studies, including the research references, methods of investigation, participant numbers, locations, and the focus on either social media or websites. This overview helps identify common trends, research gaps, and opportunities for future investigation. Several studies mostly focused on advertising and customer influence on shopping [25], [14], and [12]. Other research explored customer preferences in online versus traditional shopping [6], [15], and [1]. Trust and privacy concerns were addressed in studies by [29], [1], and [9]. Furthermore, challenges in online shopping were highlighted by Mahmud et al., [18] and Papagiannidis et al., [22], while psychological and demographic drivers were discussed by Venkatesh et al., [32] and Latief et al., [17]. Customer satisfaction and engagement factors were analyzed in studies by Nahida Sultana [30] and Saha et al., [27]. However, the existing literature lacks a focus on buyer and seller preferences when choosing between social media and websites in the Bangladeshi context. This study also explores the

underlying reasons for such preferences among Bangladeshi customers. Notably, the study by Erkan et al., [9], addresses a similar comparison between social media and websites in shopping preferences focusing on UK-specific student data. It still lacks the seller preferences which is also an important observation of our study to facilitate business growth.

## 6 Conclusion

The results of this study reveal that social media is a highly effective tool for outreach, advertising, and promotions, also in rural areas. Although websites are the preferred shopping platform, ease of use, intuitive interface, and ability to build trust emphasize the role of social media in modern business operations and customer behavior. Additionally, sellers prefer social media over websites for its ease of management, greater product visibility, higher customer inquiry volume, reputation enhancement, and superior advertising tools highlighting the critical importance of maintaining a social media presence. A balanced approach integrating both social media and websites may provide the best strategy for businesses. Future research could investigate strategies to enhance the appeal of social media as a preferred medium or explore how to effectively integrate websites and social media to leverage the strengths of both platforms.

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